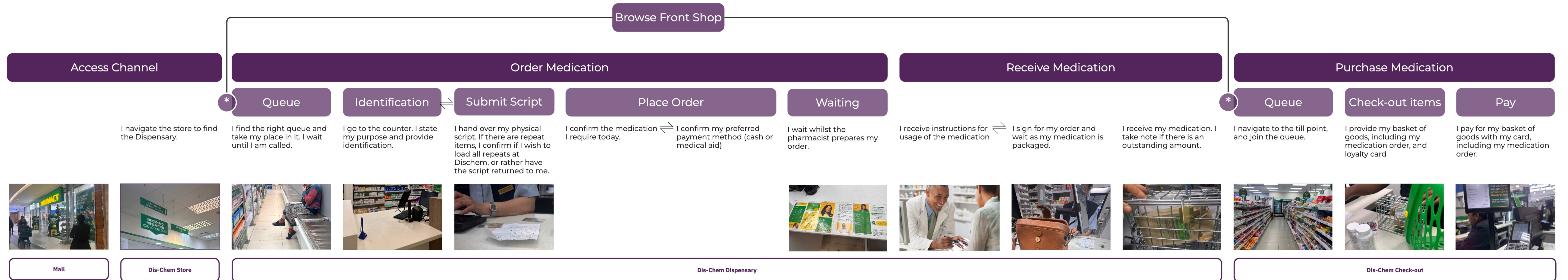


Current State Friction: High level overview

In Store



Queue confusion

Customers are often **unsure which queue to join** and frequently end up in the **wrong one**, leading to frustration when redirected. Even with signage, the **difference** between the queues isn't clear to many.

"Despite all the available signage, staff still need to redirect customers to the correct queue. It's like 'herding sheep.'" **Dispensary Manager**

Long Queues and Staffing Challenges

Customers loudly complain about **long queues and slow service**. Delays are often linked to **understaffing**, particularly on **weekends and month-end**, when demand peaks. Although multiple counters are visible, few are staffed, creating a **perception of inefficiency** and frustration for waiting customers. For customers who are **ill or physically weak**, the wait is especially challenging.

"Customers are becoming increasingly frustrated and impatient with the longer queues and slower service."
Dispensary Manager

Personal Relationships over Waiting

Despite a longer wait, some customers are **willing to wait** to be served by a **specific pharmacist** whom they trust and have built a relationship with.

{when asked if they needed help} "Oh no don't worry, I'm waiting for David. He knows my whole story." Customer seated at Dispensary

Profile Lookup Friction

Customer profile lookup can be **inconsistent, slow and frustrating**. With duplicate surnames, changing surnames, and varying ID requirements, lookup can take several minutes while staff try different search combinations. This causes **delays, repeated questions**, and customer **frustration** — and can even lead to customers unable to collect their medication.

"Couldn't pick up my mom's profile. Had to re-register. Asked for address, name and even ID but didn't pick up at all. Strange as have been to dischem multiple times. Even gave dischem card plus both surnames (married, non-married). With clicks I can go anywhere." Customer 2

Scripts Not Accessible Across Stores

Scripts are **not visible across branches**, even when customers have a profile. Pharmacists must contact the original store where the script was filled.

Slow or Opaque Script Processing

Some customers experience **long waits during script processing**, especially for longer or more complex scripts. The process feels **opaque** - customers can see activity behind the counter but don't understand what's causing the delay. This creates a perception of **inefficiency** or "slow systems," reducing confidence in the process and contributing to irritation and the sense that their time is being wasted.

Unclear prescriptions, doctor follow-ups, medical-authorisations, and slow computer systems all lengthen the process **Dispensary Manager Survey**

Staff Friendliness and Familiarity

Many customers praise staff for their **friendliness and personal connections**. Regulars feel recognised and appreciated by pharmacists who greet them by name and ask about their wellbeing.

"Always friendly to everyone. Service and energy is good. Can hear them greet the regulars."
Customer 3

Pharmacists Helpful and Knowledgeable

Customers consistently praise Dis-Chem pharmacists for being **approachable, patient, and knowledgeable**. They are valued not only for dispensing medication but also for offering **personalised advice**, recommending **cheaper or alternative options**, and even **calling medical aids** to resolve issues.

"They're familiar with me and my medication; they even recommend what might help better."

Customer 5

Delays While Waiting for Pharmacist Sign-Off

Customers often experience **frustrating waits while dispensary staff wait for a pharmacist** to become available to check or approve medication. Pharmacists are frequently called away to assist others, leaving both staff and customers waiting often **without any explanation**. The result is a visible loss of patience and perceived inefficiency at the counter.

"Customers irritated when only one pharmacist on duty and they have to wait to be signed off."

Dispensary Manager

Pharmacist Consultation Adds Meaningful Value

Customers appreciate the **time and care pharmacists take to explain medication use**. They value demonstrations, practical advice, and personalised recommendations that make the process easier to follow once at home. This consultative approach builds trust and confidence, especially when contrasted with experiences at other pharmacies where customers are left to "figure it out" themselves.

"They explain it nicely and show you the box — that makes me feel confident I'm taking the right thing."
Customer 7

Co-payments and medical-aid issues

Patients complain about **unexpected levies, incorrect benefits, and funds being depleted** without warning.

*"med aid funds being depleted."
"Co-payments, to get a new repeat."
"Levy is too high / incorrect."
Dispensary Managers*

Script not loaded / missing

Customer complaints around their handed-in scripts **not being loaded, lost or not visible on the app.**

Dispensing Errors and Omissions

Customer complaints around receiving the **wrong medication or dose.**

"Five times in a row they've got the medication wrong, not as per the script – wrong milligrams [the] product". This reviewer was even warned doctors that Dis-Chem is "renowned for giving the wrong medication" **Long-time chronic patient**
Hello Peter

Payment Process Adds Extra Waiting

After collecting medication, customers often have to **queue again to pay**, with queues that are most often longer than the dispensary queue. This makes the **final step of the visit feel like the slowest and most inefficient**, sometimes leading customers to browse further until queues shorten.

“...patients that are just getting a script sometimes irritated because they have to re-queue to pay ... can't they just pay while dispensing is their question?”

Dispensary Manager